



The Reading Slot

Everything you need for a form time reading slot that nobody gave you a plan for: a bookmark of six things to think about whatever the book is, a reading log for the wall so the form can see what everybody else is on, and five different ways to run the twenty minutes when reading in silence has stopped working. Print once and it lasts the year. It builds focus, which for most students is harder than the reading itself.

Print these

Page	What it is
Page 2	The bookmarks, four to a sheet, on card if you have it. Eight sheets for a form of thirty.
Page 3	The form reading log. Two sheets for a form of thirty.
Page 4	Twenty minutes, five ways. For you, not for them.

How it works

Step	What happens
Before	Get hold of a crate of about twenty books and keep them in the room. Page 4 says what goes in it. This is the part that decides whether the slot works.
1	Print the bookmarks on card, cut them out and put the log on the wall. Fill in your own row on it first, with whatever you are actually reading.
2	Hand out a bookmark each. Say that the six questions are for thinking about and that nothing here gets marked or written down.
3	Run the slot. Books out before the register, not after it, and read yourself where they can see you.
4	Use one of the other four ways on page 4 roughly once a fortnight. Silent reading every single time is what kills it by half term.

Worth knowing

- A student who is not reading is nearly always a student with nothing they want to read. It is much more often a supply problem than an attitude problem, which is why the crate comes first.
- Do not put a page count or a book count anywhere. The moment it is measured, the fast readers read short books and the slow ones stop.
- Nothing on the bookmark is about the plot, on purpose. Six questions that work on any book are worth more than a worksheet for one.
- If your school has set a reading scheme, this still works underneath it. The log and the bookmark do not care what the book is.
- Paper bookmarks last about a fortnight. On card they last the year, and a student who has kept the same bookmark since September is a student who has kept reading.

Get the crate first. Everything else here is easy and that part is not.





The bookmarks

Four to a sheet, printed on card if you can. Cut round the outside of the green line and give one to every student to keep in whatever they are reading.

While you read

Six things to think about, whatever the book is.

- 1**
What has just changed for the person this is about?
- 2**
What do they want, and what is in the way of it?
- 3**
Why has the writer told you this bit now, and not earlier?
- 4**
What would you have done in their place?
- 5**
Which word on this page would you never have picked?
- 6**
What do you think happens next, and what makes you think it?

Stop when the slot stops, not at the end of the page. Leaving it in the middle of something is what makes you want to pick it up again.

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Two sheets for a form of thirty. Put it on the wall where everybody can see what everybody else is on, and fill it in yourself as well.

[illegible]
The Pastoral Guide



Twenty minutes, five ways

Keep this one. It is what to do with the slot when reading in silence has stopped working, and what to do about the students who never have anything with them.

The way	What you do
Just read	The default, and the one to use most weeks. Everybody reads, including you, sitting where they can see you doing it. A tutor marking books during silent reading tells the room it does not matter.
The first page	You read the first page of something out loud on a Monday and then stop. Anybody who wants to know what happens next can take it. Two minutes, and it is the single best way to move a book that nobody has picked up.
Two minutes each	In pairs, two minutes each way: say what yours is about without saying whether it is any good. The rule is what makes it work, because it stops the conversation being a review and makes it a description.
The swap	Once a half term, anybody who has finished something brings it in and it goes round the room. Books that arrive from another student get read; books that arrive from a teacher get carried around.
The abandon rule	One Friday a half term, anybody can give up on a book. They say one sentence about why they are stopping, put it back, and start something else. Nobody finishes a book they have hated, and everybody learns to say why.

The student with nothing to read

Keep a box, not a reading list. Three or four students will need a book every week, and one sent to the library has lost the slot. A crate of about twenty things in the room solves it: whatever the library will let you keep for a term, anything the form has finished with, and a handful of short ones for the student who has never got to the end of a book. Nothing in the crate has to be improving, and the short ones do most of the work.

Worth knowing

- Twenty minutes of actual reading is the target, so the slot has to start faster than it usually does. Every minute spent finding a book is a minute gone.
- The log on page 3 does more than the bookmark does. A form that can see what everybody else is reading starts recommending things to each other by about week three.
- Read something yourself and let them see the cover. Half of them have never watched an adult read for pleasure.
- Do not turn it into comprehension. The six questions on the bookmark are for thinking about, not for answering on paper, and nothing about this slot gets marked.

Start with the crate and with Just read, and add one of the other four when the room tells you it needs it.

